

BHARAT JODO, PART II
Rahul Gandhi greeting supporters in Prayagraj during a yatra stopover, Feb. 18

AFP

against the party till after the Lok Sabha polls. But there was no mistaking the intent of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Beyond its rallying cry of a brute majority of *'char sau paar'*, the BJP's rivals sense a more sinister design—to annihilate all opposition. To do so, the ruling party is willing to use all means at its disposal—engineering splits, poaching or arresting leaders and choking party finances.

Up against the BJP's relentless poll machinery—powered by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's personal popularity, his perceived performance record along with his party's Hindu nationalist agenda and the plank of development—this Lok Sabha election has become a test of political relevance for the Opposition camp. The BJP has humiliated them twice, winning back-to-back majorities in the 543-member House on its own—282 seats in 2014 and 303 in 2019. Its combined tally with its allies in the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) was 352 in 2019. This time, the BJP is gunning for 370 seats on its own and 400-plus for the larger alliance.

In what appears to be a completely dismal scenario, the Opposition can draw solace from the fact that the BJP's vote share in 2019 was 38 per cent and the NDA's 45 per cent; 55 per cent of the electorate had voted for parties opposing the BJP. That statistic demanded that Opposition parties combine forces to try and halt the BJP juggernaut. Ergo, the formation of I.N.D.I.A. last June. That promise, though, was soon belied by Bihar chief minister and Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) chief Nitish Kumar bolting to the saffron side, robbing the alliance of a crucial pivot. In neighbouring battlefield West Bengal, where the BJP as the main opposition force had captured more than 40 per cent of the vote share in 2019, the Mamata Banerjee-led ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC) continued support for the I.N.D.I.A. bloc but decided to fight the election solo. Dealt these crushing blows, does I.N.D.I.A. still have it in them to topple Modi and the BJP?

I.N.D.I.A. CAN TAKE HEART FROM THE FACT THAT THE NDA HAD A VOTE SHARE OF 45 PER CENT IN 2019. FIFTY-FIVE PER CENT OF THE ELECTORATE THUS VOTED FOR RIVAL PARTIES

CONGRESS IS STILL KEY

Despite its apparent disarray, the Grand Old Party remains the single-largest challenger to the ruling BJP. Congress success or failure at the hustings will make or break I.N.D.I.A.'s chances of ending the NDA rule. In at least 200 Lok Sabha seats, the Congress is in direct contest with the ruling party. Of the 303 seats the BJP won last time, the Congress was its primary rival in 190. However, the GOP managed to win only 15 of them, with the remaining 175 going to the BJP, a strike rate of 92 per cent for the saffron side. The overall difference in vote share was 20 percentage points, to fill which gap the alliance will require a massive wave in its favour. "It's an extremely challenging task for the